

your computer via the USB cable. This will help in configuring the computer to use the SIM card and a connection will be established with the service provider. This is a one-time process, after which the router can be disconnected and used as a modem or a Wi-Fi hotspot.

**USB data card with the option of enabling the Wi-Fi hotspot.** Some current USB dongles offer the built-in Wi-Fi option, which helps in sharing the Internet connection with other users too. They do not require a separate Wi-Fi hotspot to offer wide Internet connectivity.

**USB data card or modem-based Wi-Fi hotspot devices.** In this case, you need to have a USB data card. Plug in the data card in the pocket Wi-Fi router and turn it on to access the Internet via various Wi-Fi enabled gadgets. For initial configuration, connect the device to your computer via the USB cable. Access the admin panel through the browser and get going. These Wi-Fi routers do not feature an in-built modem but use the USB data card for connectivity with the service provider. The router acts as a Wi-Fi hotspot and shares Internet access with devices.

## Which one is better?

Although SIM-based Wi-Fi hotspot devices and USB data cards with the optional Wi-Fi hotspot seem different from each other, they are pretty similar with regard to their functionalities. Both the devices can function as a Wi-Fi hotspot and share Internet access amongst various users and devices. However, in most cases, the USB data cards are vendor-locked, so users cannot replace the SIM or change the service provider. But in the case of SIM-based Wi-Fi hotspots, users are free to replace the SIM and switch over to a different service provider.

SIM-based pocket Wi-Fi routers are good for those who travel on a frequent basis. They can change their SIM depending upon the availability of services in different regions they travel to. They are slightly bigger than

a USB data card, but their rectangular shape makes them convenient to handle, while on the go.

## Factors to keep in mind while buying a pocket Wi-Fi router

**Vendor-locked/unlocked.** This is the most important factor to consider while planning to buy a pocket Wi-Fi router. If you are getting a device for a cheaper rate compared to other devices available in the market, the chances are that it is locked in with a particular vendor. In the case of locked devices, you do not have the option of switching to another vendor with the same device. Hence, it is strongly recommended that if you are buying a pocket router, go in for an unlocked device even if you have to spend a little extra in the beginning. You will have the freedom to switch over from one vendor to another to get a better data plan, or while you are travelling.

**The number of devices you can connect.** Most of the latest pocket routers allow a maximum of five devices to be connected, which is reasonable. But, if you want a device to be used in a larger set-up like in a small office or a big family, check out devices that can offer connectivity to a large number of users.

**Data plan.** If you are opting for a vendor-locked device, do check out the minute details of the plan. You need to decide whether to buy a prepaid or a post-paid plan, compare that with the packs provided by other service providers, evaluate the service, et al.

**Regions covered by your service provider.** For travellers, this is an important point to consider. Before you sign on with a service provider, do check out the regions covered. Not every Internet service provider can cover all the areas. Also check the compatibility features of your Wi-Fi router. Not every Wi-Fi router is compatible with all service providers. ●

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